

Research Proposal Writing

Penulisan Proposal (CCK4CAB2)

Course: Proposal Writing · Meeting 1 of 4 · Duration 100 minutes

01

Understanding the Research Proposal



What the document **is**, what it **claims**, and who it has to **convince**.

What it is

A plan for a study or project that outlines the idea, approach, and expected outcomes.

What it claims

It presents a problem worth studying and proposes a solution or contribution that matters.

Who it convinces

It persuades reviewers, funders, or decision-makers that the study is important, feasible, and impactful.

What Is a Research Proposal?



DEFINITION

A research proposal is a **structured, persuasive** document describing an investigation that has not yet been carried out — and arguing that the work is worth doing, that it can be done, and that you are the person able to do it.

Structured

It follows conventions your readers already expect. Surprising them with an invented format costs you credibility, not points for originality.

Why it matters:
A clear structure helps reviewers quickly find what they need and assess your proposal fairly.

Persuasive

It is not a neutral description. Every section is evidence in an argument that this study deserves approval, time, and resources.

Why it matters:
You must convince reviewers that the problem is important and your plan is the right solution.

Prospective

It describes work in the future tense. You have no findings yet — only a defensible plan and a justified expectation.

Why it matters:
Reviewers fund potential.
Show them what you will do,
why it will work, and what it can achieve.

A Proposal Makes Three Claims



THE UNDERLYING ARGUMENT

Every section you write exists to support one of these three claims. If a paragraph supports none of them, it does not belong in the document.

This is worth doing



The reader asks: so what?

- **A real, bounded problem exists**
  The problem is clear and specific.
- **Prior work has not settled it**
  A gap or limitation justifies your study.
- **Someone benefits from an answer**
  The study has value for people or practice.

This can be done



The reader asks: really?

- **Scope fits the time available**
  The study is realistic and manageable.
- **Access to data or participants is secured**
  You can obtain what you need.
- **Resources and skills are in place**
  The team and tools can deliver the plan.

This is the right way to do it



The reader asks: how?

- **Method matches the question**
  The approach is appropriate and justified.
- **Procedures are specific enough to repeat**
  Others could understand and replicate it.
- **Limits are acknowledged, not hidden**
  You address potential risks and constraints.

Three claims. One proposal. When these three claims work together, your proposal becomes clear, credible, and convincing.

Four Things a Proposal Does for You



PURPOSE

It secures approval

Supervisors, committees, ethics boards, and funders use it to decide whether the work proceeds at all.



It is your working plan

Once approved it becomes the schedule you work from: what to read, whom to contact, what to collect, and when.



It sets the scope

It records what you agreed to do — and, just as usefully, what you did not agree to do.



It attracts early critique

Weaknesses found at proposal stage cost you a paragraph. The same weaknesses found later cost you a semester.



A proposal is cheap to change and expensive to ignore.

Who Actually Reads Your Proposal?

AUDIENCE

Supervisor & examiners



Usually expert in the field but not in your exact topic.

THEY ARE ASKING

- Is the problem genuinely researchable?
- Does the student understand the literature?
- Can this be finished on time?

Reviewers & ethics boards



Reading many documents quickly, against a fixed checklist.

THEY ARE ASKING

- Are participants protected?
- Is the method defensible?
- Does it meet institutional requirements?

You, six months from now



The reader everyone forgets — and the one who suffers most.

THEY ARE ASKING

- What exactly did I promise?
- What was the analysis plan again?
- Why did I choose this design?

Different readers. Different questions. One goal: a clear, credible, and doable proposal.

Proposal vs. Final Thesis or Report



COMMON CONFUSION

They share a structure but do completely different work.
Most first drafts fail because they mix the two.

Aspect	Research proposal	Final thesis / report
Time frame	Work that has not happened yet	Work that has been completed
Dominant tense	Future: "data **will be** collected…"	Past: "data **were** collected…"
Core purpose	To convince a reader to approve, and to guide your own work	To report what was found and defend the interpretation
Findings	None — only expected outcomes and their significance	Actual results, with analysis and discussion
Treatment of risk	Feasibility argued in advance; contingencies stated	Limitations reported honestly after the fact
Typical length	Short: often 10–25 pages, institution-dependent	Long: the full account of the study

Key takeaway: A proposal asks for permission to do the study.
A thesis/report shows what you found and what it means.

One Genre, Several Contexts



TYPES OF PROPOSALS

Undergraduate thesis

Shortest form. Emphasis on a clear, narrow problem and a method the student can execute alone within one or two semesters.



Master's thesis

Requires a defensible gap in the literature and a design with real analytical depth, not only description.



Doctoral proposal

Must argue an original contribution to knowledge and survive a formal defence before a panel.



Grant or funding proposal

Adds budget justification, deliverables, and impact. Judged competitively against other applications.



Ethics committee submission

A narrower document focused on participants, consent, risk, and data handling.



Institutional or applied study

Written for a client or organisation; usefulness of the findings is weighted as heavily as rigour.



The conventions differ; the underlying argument does not. | Always check your own institution's template first. |



The First Five Minutes of Reading



READER EXPECTATIONS

Experienced readers form a judgement early. These are the five questions they try to answer before deciding how carefully to read the rest.

1. **What exactly is the problem being addressed?**
   The reader looks for a clear problem statement and defined scope.
2. **Why does it matter, and to whom?**
   The reader checks the significance and who benefits from the answer.
3. **What is already known, and what is still missing?**
   The reader scans the literature context and the research gap.
4. **What will the researcher actually do, step by step?**
   The reader wants a clear, feasible plan and a logical method.
5. **Can it be finished with the time, access, and resources available?**
   The reader checks feasibility and whether risks are acknowledged.

First impression matters.

If a reader cannot answer these after your first two pages, the rest of the document is rarely read with much patience.



02

The Anatomy of a Proposal

Section by section: what each part must accomplish for the argument.



The Standard Structure



ANATOMY

A proposal is organized into three parts that guide the reader from context to plan to evidence.

FRONT MATTER

Orientation. Read first, written last.

Title page
Identifies the work and author.

Abstract
Summary of the problem, method, and expected outcomes.

Table of contents
Map of the proposal for quick navigation.

THE BODY

The argument itself.
Weeks 2, 3, and 4.

1. **Introduction**
   Context, problem statement, objectives, and significance.
2. **Literature review**
   What is known, what is missing, and why your study is needed.
3. **Methodology**
   Design, data, participants, procedures, and analysis plan.

BACK MATTER

Evidence of planning and rigour.

Timeline
Schedule of activities and milestones.

Budget (if required)
Resources and cost justification.

References
Sources cited in the proposal.

Appendices
Supporting documents and tools.

How it works together:
Front matter sets the stage → The body makes the case → **Back matter** proves it is feasible and well-planned.

Section names and order vary between institutions and disciplines. The functions below do not.

Getting the Title Right

FRONT MATTER

The title is read by everyone and re-read by no one.
It should name the variables or phenomenon, the population, and the context.



A GOOD TITLE IS

- **Specific:** names what is studied, not the general area
- **Informative:** signals the design or relationship examined
- **Concise:** usually under 15–20 words
- **Searchable:** contains the terms others would search for
- **Sober:** no slogans, no questions, no promotional adjectives

TOO BROAD

"A Study About Social Media and Students"

Too general, lacks specifics about variables, population, context, and design. Not very searchable.



BOUNDED AND SEARCHABLE

"Short-Term Video Use and Sleep Quality Among Undergraduate Students in Bandung"

Names the variables (video use, sleep quality), population (undergraduate students), and context (Bandung), and implies a measurable relationship.



Test: could a stranger predict your method and population from the title alone?

The Abstract in Five Moves



FRONT MATTER

Typically 150–300 words. Write it last, when you already know what the proposal says.

1 Context

One or two sentences on the situation the reader must accept as real.

Set the scene: why this topic matters.

2 Problem

The specific gap, tension, or unanswered question.

State the exact problem, not the general area.

3 Aim

What the study sets out to do, and its main question.

Be clear about the objective.

4 Method

Design, participants, and how data will be produced.

Mention the key design and data source.

5 Contribution

What will be known, or usable, once the study is finished.

Show the expected value or impact.

If your abstract cannot be written clearly, the problem is usually in the proposal, not in the abstract.

Section 1 — The Introduction

PREVIEW OF WEEK 2

Its job: to convince the reader that a specific problem exists and deserves attention.

TYPICAL COMPONENTS

- **Background:** the wider situation, established with citations
- **Problem statement:** the specific difficulty or unknown
- **Research questions and objectives:** what you will answer or achieve
- **Scope and delimitations:** what is deliberately excluded
- **Significance:** who benefits from an answer
- **Definition of key terms:** terms used throughout, clearly defined

The funnel

It moves from a broad, familiar situation to one narrow question — never the reverse.



WEEK 2

We will spend the entire next meeting on this section, including how to write a problem statement that survives questioning.

TIP: A strong introduction makes the reader want to keep reading. | Write this section for someone outside your exact field.

Section 2 — The Literature Review

PREVIEW OF WEEK 3

Its job: to show what is already known, and to prove that your problem is genuinely unresolved.

WHAT IT MUST ACHIEVE

Map the field: the main positions, findings, and debates.
Example: key theories, major studies, common methods.

Synthesize: group sources by idea, not one paragraph per article.
Example: compare, contrast, and connect studies.

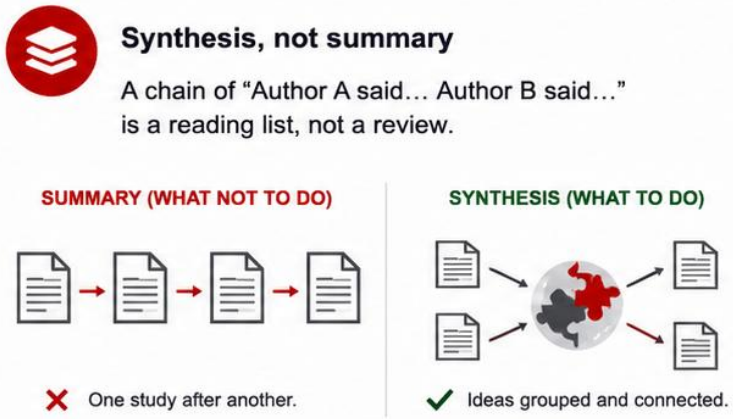
Establish the gap: what has not been settled, and why it matters.
Example: contradictions, limitations, missing populations.

Build the framework: create the conceptual or theoretical lens.
Example: key constructs and how they relate.

Justify your choices: explain why your methods fit the literature.
Example: prior evidence supporting your approach.

Synthesis, not summary

A chain of "Author A said… Author B said…" is a reading list, not a review.



WEEK 3

Searching systematically, reading efficiently, organising sources thematically, and writing the gap statement.

TIP: A strong literature review convinces the reader that your study is necessary and well grounded.

Section 3 — The Methodology

Clarity = Credibility
The clearer your methods, the more trust your results will earn.

PREVIEW OF WEEK 4

Its job: to describe the plan in enough detail that another competent researcher could carry it out.

1 Research design

Qualitative, quantitative, or mixed — and why that choice fits the question.



Choose what fits.

2 Participants & sampling

Population, sampling technique, sample size, and how access is obtained.



3 Instruments

Questionnaires, interview protocols, tests, or observation schedules, with validity evidence.



4 Procedure

The sequence of steps from first contact to final data set.



5 Analysis plan

The specific techniques or analytical framework to be applied to the data.



6 Ethics & rigour

Consent, confidentiality, approval, and how trustworthiness is protected.



THE RESEARCH PROCESS AT A GLANCE

1. **Design** — Define approach
2. **Sample** — Select participants
3. **Measure** — Collect data
4. **Analyze** — Interpret data
5. **Report** — Share findings

TIP: Imagine handing your methodology to another researcher. If they have questions, your methods need more detail.

The Parts Students Rush — and Lose Marks On

BACK MATTER

Timeline

A realistic schedule, often a simple Gantt chart. It is read as evidence that you understand the size of the task.

Task	Month					
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Literature review						
Instrument design						
Data collection						
Data analysis						
Report writing						

Show key tasks, order, and time needed for each.

Budget

Required for funded work. Every item must be traceable to an activity in the methodology.

Item	Purpose (linked to)	Cost (USD)
Survey platform	Data collection	$150
Travel	Participant access	$300
Printing	Instruments	$50
Software license	Data analysis	$200
Miscellaneous	Backup & other	$50
Total		**$750**

Clear, detailed, and linked to your plan.

References

Complete, consistent, and in the required style. Every in-text citation appears here, and vice versa.

Author (Year). Title of article. *Journal*, *Volume*(Issue), Pages. DOI

Be consistent in style, punctuation, and formatting.

Appendices

Instruments, consent forms, permission letters — anything that supports the plan without interrupting it.

Questionnaire
Consent form
Interview guide
Permission letter
...

Label clearly and refer to them in the main text.

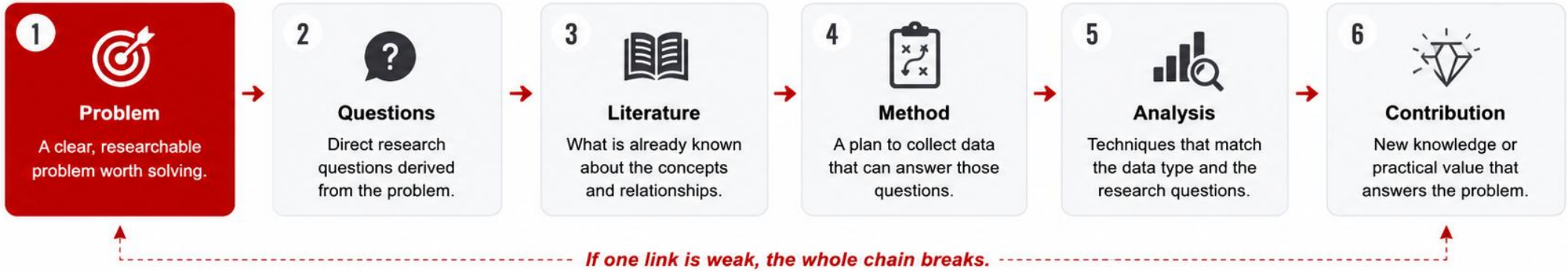
These sections take an afternoon to do properly and are the cheapest marks in the entire document.
Reviewers read a careless reference list as a signal about the care taken everywhere else.

- ✓ Plan carefully
- ✓ Check details
- ✓ Present neatly

The Golden Thread

COHERENCE

Each element must follow from the one before it. Misalignment between question and method is the single most common structural failure.



ALIGNMENT CHECK

Does every research question come directly from the stated problem?	*Questions should be specific, answerable, and necessary.*
Does the literature review discuss the concepts your questions actually use?	*Focus on sources that inform your variables and framework.*
Can the chosen method produce data that answers those exact questions?	*Method must fit the question, not the other way around.*
Does the analysis plan match the type of data the method produces?	*Use techniques appropriate for the data and objectives.*

TIP: Reread your proposal from left to right. Each section should feel like the only logical next step.

03

Getting the Core Right

Topic, problem, questions, and the limits of what you can realistically do.



Topic
Focus on a clear, researchable area.

Problem
Define the real gap or difficulty.

Questions
Ask focused, answerable questions.

Limits
Be realistic about time, data, and resources.

From Topic to Researchable Question

NARROWING

A topic is what you are interested in. A research question is what you can actually answer with evidence.

1. TOPIC
Online learning

Start broad. This is your area of interest.

↓

2. FOCUSED AREA
Student engagement in online learning

Narrow the topic to a specific aspect you care about and can study.

↓

3. PROBLEM
Engagement drops sharply in asynchronous courses, but the reasons are not well established in the Indonesian context

State the gap or problem clearly and in context. Why does it matter?

↓

4. QUESTION
How are feedback timing and peer interaction related to student engagement in asynchronous undergraduate courses?

Turn the problem into an answerable question that can be studied with data.

TIP: *Each step should make your focus smaller, clearer, and more answerable.*

Go broad → specific → clear → answerable.

What Makes a Problem Researchable?

THE RESEARCH PROBLEM

1	**Bounded**	It has edges. You can say what is inside the study and what is deliberately left out.
2	**Supported by evidence**	You can cite something showing the problem exists — data, prior studies, or documented practice.
3	**Answerable with data**	It can be settled by observation or measurement, not only by opinion or belief.
4	**Not already settled**	Existing work has not answered it, or has answered it only in a different context.
5	**Consequential**	Someone — a field, an institution, a group of people — is better off once it is answered.



TIP: If your problem is too broad, unsupported, opinion-based, already solved, or inconsequential, your study will struggle. Strengthen these five qualities.

1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5

Testing Your Question: FINER

QUALITY CRITERIA

A widely used checklist for judging whether a research question is worth committing to.

F — Feasible



Can be answered with the **time, participants, funding, and expertise** actually available to you.

Ask yourself:
Do I have what I need?

I — Interesting



Worth the attention of your supervisor, your field, and — importantly — of you for a whole semester.

Ask yourself:
Will I stay motivated?

N — Novel



Adds something: a new population, context, variable, method, or a confirmation that is genuinely needed.

Ask yourself:
What new knowledge will it create?

E — Ethical



Can be pursued without harming participants and will pass institutional review.

Ask yourself:
Is it the right thing to do?

R — Relevant



Connects to real concerns in the discipline, in practice, or in policy.

Ask yourself:
Who will care about the answer?

HOW TO USE IT | 1 Write your draft question. → 2 Run it through F–I–N–E–R. → 3 Revise until it earns all five.

Tip: A question that fails one of the letters will likely fail the proposal later.

Questions, Objectives, and Hypotheses

TERMINOLOGY

Three related statements that students routinely confuse. They describe the same study from different angles.

Research question

What you want to find out, written as a question.



How is feedback timing related to student engagement in asynchronous undergraduate courses?

Interrogative. One main question, two or three sub-questions.

Objective

What you will do to answer it, written as an action.



To examine the relationship between feedback timing and student engagement in asynchronous courses.

Begins with an infinitive verb: to examine, to compare, to describe.

Hypothesis

What you expect to find, stated so it can be tested.



Students receiving feedback within 24 hours show higher engagement than those receiving it after 72 hours.

Only where the design allows testing; not used in most qualitative studies.

Remember:
They work together.
Each one leads to the next.

Ask a clear question → Set an objective to answer it → State a testable expectation (if appropriate) → Design the study and collect data

Weak and Stronger Research Questions

WORKED EXAMPLES

Weak version	What is wrong	Stronger version
Is social media good for students?	Evaluative, unbounded, no population, cannot be settled by data	How is daily short-term video use associated with reported sleep quality among first-year undergraduates? Population · Context · Measurable
What is the role of motivation in learning?	Enormous scope; "role" is undefined; no context or measure	How does achievement motivation relate to completion rates in a semester-long online statistics course? Population · Context · Measurable
Why do employees resign?	Assumes a single cause; no organisation, period, or method implied	What reasons do junior staff give for voluntary resignation from private hospitals in West Java between 2023 and 2025? Population · Context · Measurable

THE PATTERN

Stronger questions are specific and researchable because they add three things:

- **Population** — Who or what is studied
- **Context** — Where, when, or in what setting
- **Measurable relationship** — What variables are involved and how they relate

Tip: If your question cannot be measured, it cannot be answered. Add who, where/when, and what.

The Feasibility Check



SCOPE CONTROL

Ambition is free at proposal stage and very expensive afterwards. Answer these honestly before you commit.

Time

How many weeks remain after approval, ethics clearance, and instrument preparation?



Access

Who must give permission for you to reach these participants — and have you asked yet?



Data

Does the data you need exist, and can you legally and practically obtain it?



Skills

Can you already perform the analysis you are proposing, or must you learn it first?



Cost

Transport, incentives, transcription, software — who pays, and how much?



Clearance

Does the study need ethics approval, and how long does that process take here?



★ *A smaller study finished well is worth far more than an ambitious study abandoned in month four.*

A quick reality check saves time, money, and stress.

Check each area honestly → Adjust scope to what is feasible → Plan resources realistically → Increase your chance of completion

04

Writing, Quality, and Next Steps

Style, integrity, assessment criteria, and what to prepare for Week 2.



Writing Style

Clear, concise, and academically appropriate.

Academic Integrity

Honesty, citation, and responsible use of sources.

Assessment Criteria

What reviewers look for — and how you will be evaluated.

Week 2 Preparation

Checklist and deadlines to help you stay ahead.

Academic Style in a Proposal



WRITING

Good academic writing helps your idea be understood, trusted, and taken seriously.

DO

- Use precise verbs: measure, compare, describe, evaluate
- Define each key term once, then use it consistently
- Support every factual claim with a citation
- Signpost: tell the reader what each section will do
- Use future tense for your plan, present tense for established facts
- Keep paragraphs to one idea, opening with a topic sentence

EXAMPLE – DO

This study will examine the relationship between feedback timing and student engagement in asynchronous undergraduate courses during the 2024/2025 academic year (Robinson, 2020).

AVOID

- Vague quantifiers: many studies, a lot of, very significant
- Unsupported assertions presented as common knowledge
- Stacked quotations standing in place of your own analysis
- Promotional language: revolutionary, groundbreaking, perfect
- Switching terms mid-document for the same concept
- Long paragraphs that bury the point in the final sentence

EXAMPLE – AVOID

Many studies show that feedback is very important and has a big impact on students. It is widely believed that this is the case and therefore this study will be perfect for improving learning.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Clarity is not decoration. Choose words that mean exactly what you intend, support them with evidence, and guide the reader from start to finish.

Builds credibility | Respects your reader | Strengthens your proposal

Ethics and Academic Integrity



NON-NEGOTIABLES

These are the baseline responsibilities for every research proposal.

Informed consent

Participants must understand what they are joining, and be free to withdraw without penalty.

Respect autonomy and choice.

Confidentiality

State how data will be stored, anonymised, retained, and eventually destroyed.

Protect identity and privacy.

Approval first

Ethics clearance is obtained before any data is collected — never retrospectively.

Get approval, then start.

Honest citation

Cite the source you actually read. Plagiarism and self-plagiarism both count as misconduct.

Give credit where it's due.

Responsible AI use

Follow your institution's policy: disclose assistance, verify every reference, never present generated text as your own analysis.

Be transparent and accountable.

Do no harm

Consider psychological, social, and professional risk to participants, not only physical risk.

Minimize risk, maximize care.

A fabricated citation is treated as fabricated data.
Check that every reference exists and says what you claim it says.

Why Proposals Get Sent Back



COMMON FAILURES

Almost every rejection an experienced reviewer writes falls into one of these six patterns.

1

The problem is never actually stated

The reader finishes the introduction still unsure what question the study answers.

✓ Fix it: State the research problem and question explicitly.

2

The method does not fit the question

A survey is proposed for a question about lived experience, or interviews for a question about prevalence.

✓ Fix it: Match the method to the question and data needed.

3

The literature review is a list

Sources are summarised one by one, with no synthesis and no gap identified.

✓ Fix it: Synthesize themes and show the research gap.

4

The method is too vague to repeat

"Data will be analysed using thematic analysis" — with no procedure, coder, or framework specified.

✓ Fix it: Provide specific steps, tools, and decision rules.

5

The scope is unrealistic

Three populations, two instruments, and a longitudinal design in a single semester.

✓ Fix it: Narrow the focus; align aims, time, and resources.

6

Careless presentation

Inconsistent referencing, unlabelled tables, typographic errors, missing sections.

✓ Fix it: Follow formatting guidelines and proofread carefully.

Remember: Reviewers are not rejecting you — they are protecting the quality of the research. Address these issues early to save time for everyone.

Writing Is Iterative, Not Linear

PROCESS

Nobody writes a good proposal in one pass. Expect three to five substantial drafts before submission.



1 Read widely

Scan the field before committing to a direction.

Focus: Understand the landscape.

2 Narrow

Cut the topic down until one clear question remains.

Focus: Define the core question.

3 Draft badly

Produce a full rough version; do not polish sentence one.

Focus: Get ideas down completely.

4 Seek critique

Show it to your supervisor and a peer early, not late.

Focus: Improve substance.

5 Revise

Rewrite for alignment, then for clarity, then for format.

Focus: Refine and finalize.

Remember:
Start a reference manager on day one. Reconstructing citations at the end costs far more time than it saves.

1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5

Five Things to Remember

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Use these principles to guide every decision you make while writing your proposal.

1. **A proposal is an argument, not a description**
   It persuades a reader that the work is worth doing, doable, and soundly designed.



2. **Structure is a service to the reader**
   Follow the expected sections; save your originality for the ideas inside them.



3. **The question governs everything**
   Literature, method, and analysis all exist to serve one clearly stated question.



4. **Narrow further than feels comfortable**
   Scope is the most common cause of a study that never finishes.



5. **Write early, revise often, seek critique**
   The cheapest place to fix a study is on the page, before any data exists.





Thank You